DOHA COLLEGE

DOHA COLLEGE MODEL UNITED NATIONS

DCMUN XVIII

PRE CONFERENCE BOOKLET

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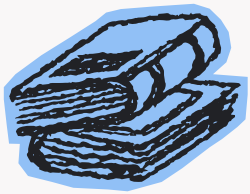

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ABOUT THE CONFERENCE

DCMUN XVIII is the 18th annual Doha College Model United Nations conference and is set to take place from the 5th to the 7th of November 2026. DCMUN is one of the largest student-led conferences in the MENA region.

CONFERENCE THEME

UNREST

The world feels out of our control, even more than usual. Many things that are failing our general population, especially vulnerable minorities. Right now, to be realistic is often associated with being pessimistic, or addressing dissatisfaction. How can we use the unrest caused by this to result in positive progress?

OUR SECETARY GENERALS

Adhithi Karthikeyan

My name is Adhithi Karthikeyan, and it is my privilege to welcome you to DCMUN XVIII as your Secretary-General. Since first starting MUN in Year 7, it has remained a meaningful part of my secondary school journey, both at Doha College and through THIMUN.

Having experienced DCMUN from several perspectives: from admin, to the International Court of Justice and executive leadership, I have come to appreciate the many ways it can shape those who take part, and I am so grateful for the opportunity to bring these experiences to this year's conference.

One of the things that makes MUN so valuable is its ability to connect our experiences as students to the realities of the world around us. The issues we debate reflect a world grappling with conflict, political divisions and increasingly complex international relationships, where decisions made by governments and international organisations have consequences for people across the globe. By engaging with these challenges, we are encouraged to look beyond the headlines, consider perspectives different from our own and explore the complexities of finding common ground where agreement is rarely simple. Whether MUN is your introduction to international affairs or an opportunity to deepen an existing interest, I hope this conference challenges you to think critically about the world we live in.

As we begin DCMUN XVIII, I encourage you to approach the coming days with curiosity, an open mind and a willingness to engage with ideas that may challenge your own.

Thank you for being part of DCMUN XVIII. I look forward to seeing what this year's conference brings.

OUR SECETARY GENERALS

Mary Kurian

I am Mary Kurian, and I am honoured to welcome you to DCMUN XVIII as your Secretary-General. Having been part of MUN for several years, I have come to appreciate its ability to bring people together across differences, challenge perspectives and turn disagreement into meaningful dialogue.

In a world increasingly shaped by unrest, conflict and uncertainty, it is easy to feel that lasting peace is beyond our reach. Yet, it is through diplomacy, mutual understanding and the willingness to engage with perspectives different from our own that we can begin to address the divisions that define our world. This year, DCMUN invites us to look beyond the unrest around us and consider how dialogue can become a catalyst for change.

Over the course of this conference, I hope you challenge assumptions, engage thoughtfully and recognise the responsibility we share in shaping a more peaceful future.

Whether this is your first conference or one of many, remember that meaningful change begins with the courage to question, the patience to listen and the determination to act.

Welcome to DCMUN XVIII. As we navigate a world in turmoil, let us remember that we are not merely observers of history, but participants in shaping what comes next.

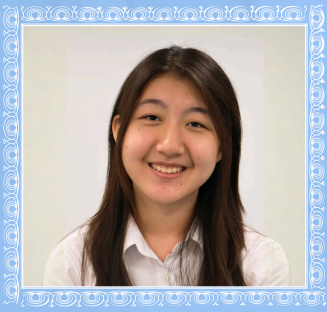
MEET OUR BIG 7

Adhithi Karthikeyan
Secretary General

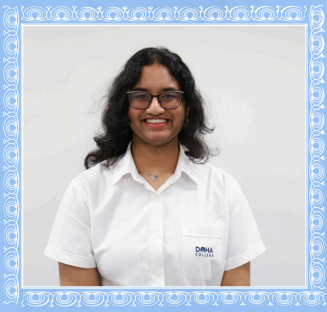
Mary Kurian
Secretary General

Jianne Lee
Deputy Secretary General

Anushka Gudavalli
Deputy Secretary General



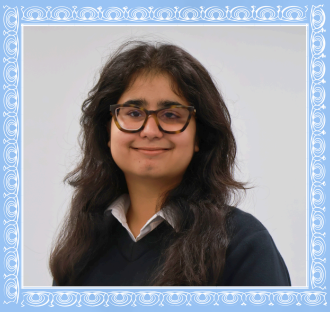
Yushi Zhang
President of General Assembly



Akshara Papineni
Deputy President of General Assembly

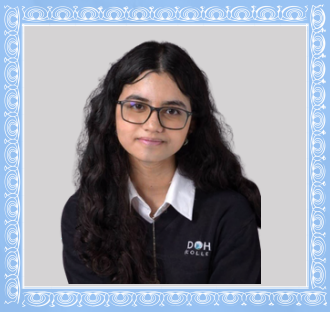
Amna Waqar
Deputy President of General Assembly

MEET OUR EXECUTIVE TEAM



Shirin Dhankhar

Head of Press

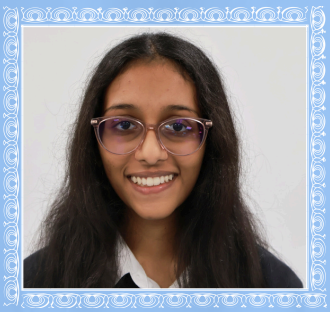


Aryana Udayar

Deputy Head of Press

Lara Skindhoj

Deputy Head of Press

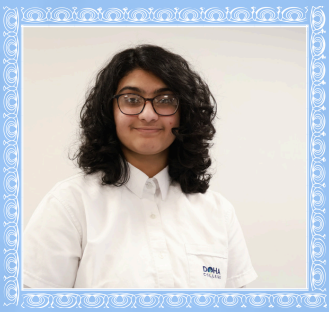


Anvita Chaitanya

President of International Court of Justice

Vedika Kumar

Deputy President of International Court of Justice



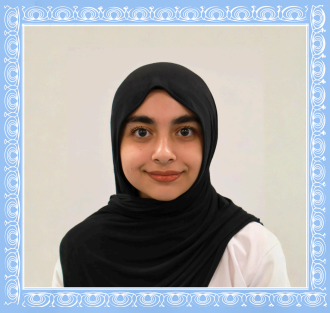
Fatima Imran

Deputy President of International Court of Justice

MEET OUR EXECUTIVE TEAM

Arianna Martella

Head of Admin



Emaan Yaqoob

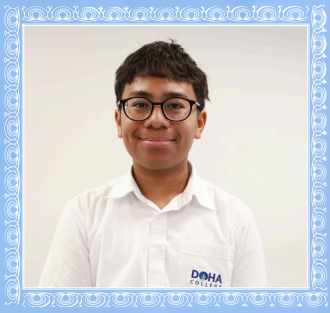
Deputy Head of Admin

Shiza Sharif

Deputy Head of Admin

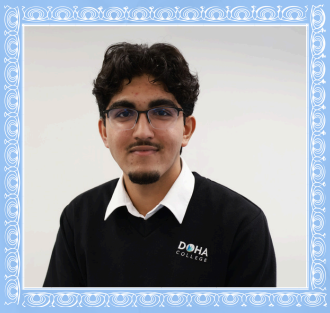
Sienna Al-Kassem

Head of DC-IMPACT



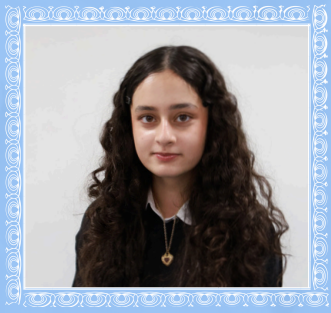
John Paul Ribeiru

Head of Training



Zuhayr Siddique

Deputy Head of Training



Maria Ali

Deputy Head of Training

CONFERENCE SCHEDULE

DAY 1 — Thursday 5th November

Time	Event	Location
3:45-4:00	Registration	Doha College
4:00-5:00	Opening Ceremony	Auditorium
04:00 PM	Committee sessions	Committee Rooms

DAY 2 — Friday 6th November

Time	Event	Location
8:45-9:00	Registration	Doha College
9:00-11:30	Committee session #1	Committee Rooms
11:30-12:00	Prayer	
12:00-1:30	Committee session #2	Committee Rooms
1:30-2:30	Lunch	
2:30-4:00	Committee session #3	Committee Rooms
4:00-4:30	Break	
4:30-5:30	Committee session #4	Committee Rooms

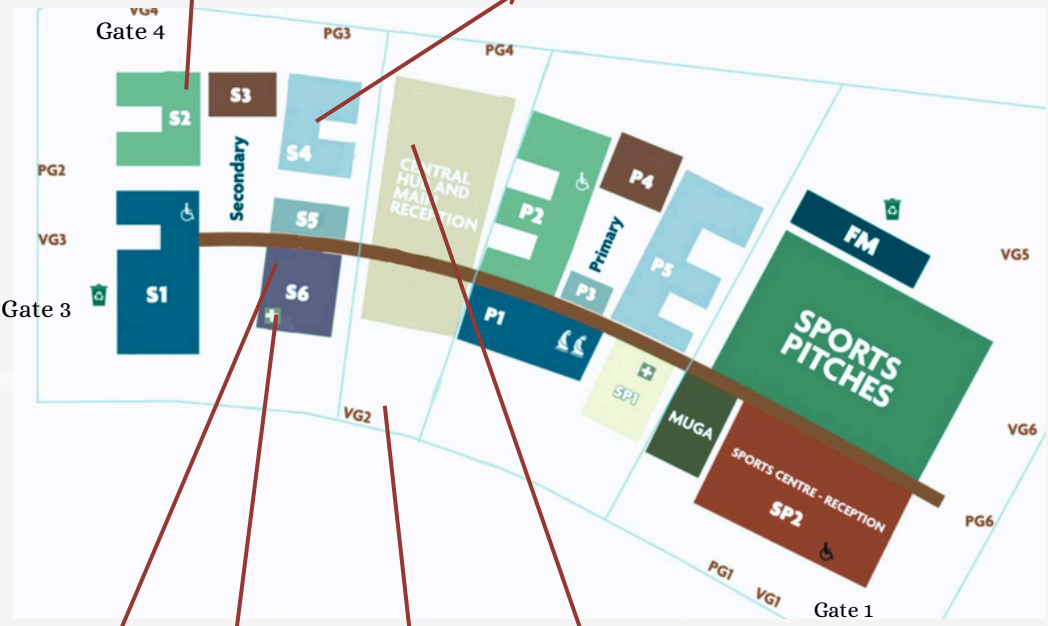
CONFERENCE SCHEDULE

DAY 3 — Saturday 7th November

Time	Event	Location
8:45-9:00	Registration	Doha College
9:00-10:30	Committee session #1	Committee Rooms
10:30-11:00	Break	
11:00-12:00	Committee session #2	Committee Rooms
12:00-3:30	Transport period	
3:30-4:00	Arrival time interval	Mondrian
4:00-4:15	Guest Speaker	
4:15-5:00	Closing Ceremony	Mondrian
5:00-6:00	Dinner	

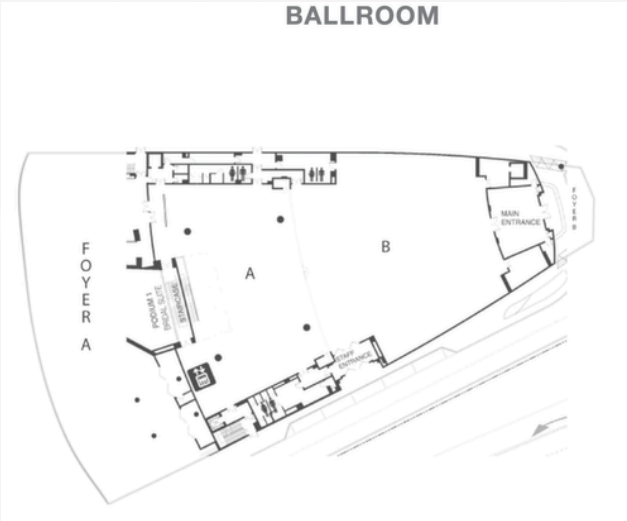
CONFERENCE VENUE

Doha College



The Mondrian (click for the link)

Located in the West Bay Lagoon area, next to the recognizable Zig Zag Towers. The closing ceremony will be in the Ballroom.



COMMITTEES AND ISSUES

GA1

Disarmament and Weapons

- Addressing the Risks of a Double Dual-Use Dilemma Regarding Private Aerospace Firms
- Regulating the Proliferation and Use of Anti-Personnel Landmines and Improvised Explosive Devices (IEDs)
- Preventing the Militarization of Quantum Computing and Cryptography

GA2

Economic and Financial Committee

- Addressing Global Supply Chain Fragmentation and its Impact on Developing Countries
- Addressing the Role of Illicit Commodity Trading in Financing Non-State Actors
- Regulating Cryptocurrency Markets and Their Impact on Financial Stability

GA3

Humanitarian and Cultural

- Measures to Provide Humanitarian Assistance to Reduce the Effect of Cyclone Gezani on Madagascar
- Addressing Systematic Barriers to Equal Employment Opportunities for University Graduates

GA4

Special Political and Decolonization

- Preventing the Exploitation of Resources and Militarisation of Non-Self-Governing Territories
- Assessing the Progress Towards a Referendum on the Self-Determination of the Sahrawi People

GA5

Administration and Budgetary Matters

- Preventing Concurrent UN Emergencies from Overwhelming Administrative Capacity
- Assessing the Involvement of Private Sector Partnerships with the UN

COMMITTEES AND ISSUES

GA6

Legal

- Regulating the Repatriation of Colonial-Era Cultural Heritage
- Addressing Legal Disputes Over Undersea Infrastructure Crossing National Jurisdictions
- Regulating State Responsibility for Damage to Critical Digital Infrastructure

ECOSOC

- Mitigating Corporate Monopolies on Proprietary Seed and Smart-Farming Tech
- Regulating the Influx of International NGOs to Prevent the Creation of Shadow States
- Measures to Advance Sustainable Forest-Based Bioeconomy Approaches

HRC

- De-criminalizing Homelessness and Ensuring Human Rights Protection.
- Implementing Human Rights Safeguards in the Proliferation of Mass Surveillance and Predictive Profiling Technologies
- Measures to Protect Women Migrant Domestic Workers from Forced Labour

SC

- Measures to Assist the Restoration of the Provision of Public Services in Disaster-Afflicted Nations
- Addressing the Rise of Ultra-Nationalism and the Impacts on Globalisation

HSC ANCIENT

- Determining the Political Future of France Following the Collapse of Monarchical Authority During the French Revolution, 1789
- Examining the Túpac Amaru II Rebellion and Indigenous Resistance to Spanish Colonial Rule in the Andes, 1780–1781
- Assessing the Political and Social Consequences of the Black Death and the Breakdown of Traditional Social Structures in Europe, 1347–1351

COMMITTEES AND ISSUES

HSC RECENT

- Addressing the Fragmentation of Yugoslavia and the Collapse of Federal Political Authority Across the Balkans (1991)
- Measures to Respond to the Government Crackdown of the Saffron Revolution in Myanmar (2007)

WHO

- Regulating Air Pollution Frontiers in Cross-Border Industrial Basins
- Deploying Standardized Heat-Health Protection and Urban Surveillance Systems
- Measures to Elevate the Position of Women in the Health and Care Workforce

UNICEF

- Measures to Promote Technical and Vocational Education and Training For Adolescents in Crisis-Affected Regions
- Measures to Protect Stateless Children from Systematic Discrimination and Disadvantages
- Addressing the Commercialisation of Childhood Through Social Media Platforms

WFP

- Preventing the Disruption of Food Supply Chains of Land-Locked Nations During Fuel Shocks
- Reforming Antibiotic Use in Global Agrifood Systems to Combat Superbugs

UNDP

- Combating Youth Unemployment in Communities Affected by Climate Shocks
- Addressing Housing Affordability in Urbanising Central Asian Cities
- Ensuring Local Economic Gains from Mineral Extraction in Developing Nations

COMMITTEES AND ISSUES

UNIDIR

- Addressing the Risks to National Infrastructure Caused by Electromagnetic Warfare
- Combating the Proliferation of Illicit Weapons in West Africa
- Assessing the Social Acceptance and Reintegration of Former Associates of Extremist Organisations

SDG 9

- Reassessing Environmental Ambition for Energy Sources Used in Industrialisation for Developing Nations
- Balancing the Economic Benefits of Airport Expansion in Urban Areas
- Supporting Global Access to Affordable Mobile Connectivity in Developing Countries

SDG 6

- Addressing Government Formalisation of Sanitation Workers in Informal Settlements
- Addressing Water Scarcity and Drought Management In South Africa

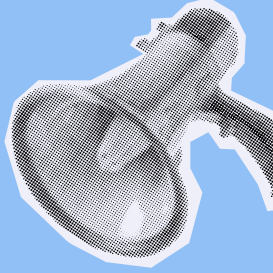
CRISIS

- Addressing the Emergence of a High-Infection Rate Pandemic Originating in Australia

ICJ

- Case 1: Border and Transborder armed actions (Nicaragua v Honduras)
- Case 2: Application of the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (Georgia v. Russian Federation)

JOURNALIST'S ARTICLES



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Race, Rights, and Realpolitik: Georgia v. Russia at the ICJ

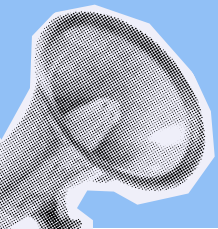
Like, Follow, Exploit: Commercialising Childhood on Social Media

Punished for Being Poor: The Case for Decriminalising Homelessness

The Silent Pandemic: Antimicrobial Resistance and the Food We Eat

Underpaid and Overlooked: Elevating Women in Health and Care

Building Back in Madagascar: Humanitarian Response to Cyclone Gezani



Who Governs the Helpers? Preventing Shadow Governance by INGOs

ECOSOC is one of the six main organs of the United Nations, and was established by the UN Charter in 1945. It acts as a platform for discussing main topics around international issues. These mainly include health, economical, cultural, social and environment issues.

International Non-Governmental Organisations (INGOs) help people around the world by providing food, healthcare, education, and emergency support. They are especially important during wars and natural disasters. However, problems can happen when these organisations become too powerful and start making decisions that should be made by governments.

This is called shadow governance, when organisations begin acting like a second government without being chosen by the people. The United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) must find ways to make sure INGOs help people without taking control away from governments.

What Is Shadow Governance?

Shadow governance happens when organisations start making important decisions about a country without having the proper authority to do so. For example, an INGO might build schools and provide education in a country. This is helpful, but problems may occur if the organisation ignores the country's laws or makes decisions without confirmation from the government. Not all INGOs cause problems. Many save lives and help people in need. However, if they are not properly controlled, they may become too powerful. People might also become too dependent on them instead of receiving long-term support from their own government.

Why Should INGOs Be Controlled?

There are several reasons why INGOs need rules.
Firstly, every country should have the right to govern itself. This means that important decisions about the country should not be controlled by outside organisations.
Secondly, rules can help prevent money from being misused. INGOs receive donations from people, companies, and governments. They should clearly explain where their money comes from and how they spend it.

Finally, rules make organisations responsible for their actions. If an INGO breaks the law or harms a community, there should be a way to investigate the problem and take action.

What Can ECOSOC Do?

ECOSOC can encourage countries to work together and create clear rules for INGOs. Governments should require INGOs to register before they begin working in a country. They should explain their goals, where their money comes from, and what they plan to do. This would help governments understand the work being carried out by these organisations.

Second, INGOs should regularly share reports about their money and activities. These reports should be checked to make sure donations are being used properly. Organisations that repeatedly break the rules could face fines or lose permission to work in that country.

Third, local people should be included in important decisions. Before starting a project, INGOs should speak to local communities and listen to their needs. This would help make sure that projects are useful and suitable for the people they are meant to help.

Finally, countries should share information about INGOs that break the rules. By working together, governments can deal with problems more effectively. However, rules should not delay emergency aid during wars, natural disasters, or other serious situations.

INGOs play an important role in helping people, but they must follow rules and respect the governments of the countries where they work. Preventing shadow governance does not mean stopping INGOs from helping people. Instead, it means making sure they use their power responsibly. Through registration, financial checks, and working with local communities, ECOSOC can help prevent INGOs from becoming too powerful. INGOs should support governments and communities, not replace them.

Samyak Palve

Whose Museum Is It Anyway? Governing the Return of Cultural Heritage

How do countries decide who keeps which artifacts from the Colonial-Era? It's rather simple actually. Many countries face difficulties when it comes to the return of cultural heritage. Let's discuss the main problems with this topic and potential solutions.

First, what is cultural heritage exactly? Cultural heritage can be anything that is a traditional artifact, practice or environment that was inherited from ancestors which are being preserved and maintained for the years to come. The return of cultural heritage is a current global movement for giving back artifacts, remains or stolen objects back to the communities they came from.

But why is it so important? This matters beyond the artifacts themselves. It lets communities connect with their past, it can fix mistakes like stealing or other injustices, and for some it can be much more personal: by bringing back cultural traditions, beliefs or history of what truly happened to their ancestors. It also helps us with preserving them for the future generations so they too can learn about the past.

A big problem when it comes to the return of cultural heritage is that some countries have rules that make it difficult to give back the items from their museums or to remove them from their collections forever. A good solution for this is to help remove these rules accordingly, depending on the situation and circumstances.

Another problem with the return of cultural heritage, is that some governments disagree on the ownership, legality, or how the artifact was obtained. Some may also worry about how it will affect their pride and image. A solution for the problem could be to dig further and get more information on who should really own it. They could do this by looking at other people's perspective giving them a basic understanding of what the public wants.

Take Britain as an example for both the problems addressed above hand. They have all sorts of incongruous artifacts so the countries of origin want them back. The Kohinoor diamond from India, which was passed through from ruler to ruler until the annexation of Punjab in 1846 — this was when the British made it part of their crown jewels. There is ongoing debate whether India should have it back.

Another example is the Elgin Marbles from Greece that was originally a part of the Parthenon. There is currently ongoing debate since Greece wants it back

Of course there are other reasons behind museums being unwilling to give back some items. One reason is that some countries might want people to be able to go to one place to learn all about different cultures instead of going all over the world, which can be both inconvenient and costly. Others think it stops countries from connecting with their past.

Altogether, this information highlights that the return of cultural heritage is how nations decide who owns what: which can be tied to cultural identity and history. This includes multiple problems like museums having big difficulty giving back artifacts to the original community, and countries may disagree about whether the information given to them is correct. Obviously there are other reasons like countries wanting it to be more convenient and easy to learn about different cultures all in one place.

But what are your thoughts on this? Do you agree with the things being said or disagree? What really is the best course of action?

Iman Khan

Dirty Work, No Rights: Recognising Sanitation Workers in the Informal City

The invisible heroes keeping our cities alive

Sanitation and clean water are essential in a human's daily life, it is a need for society. However in many informal settlements, millions of people live without that safe sanitation compared to people living in high income countries, and these people living in informal settlements need reliable services of water. The people who try and keep these settlements clean are formally known as sanitation workers.

Most of them work without fair wages or proper protection. Although their work is essential and very important for our health, they are often overlooked by the government. To ensure sustainable development goal 6, governments must recognise these workers. The law and government have the power and responsibility to achieve the goal of reliable sanitation and clean water.

For

Recognising workers would help improve workers safety as working in those horrible conditions, workers desperately need better and safer working equipment. Without equipment, they could come into contact with bacteria such as human waste and contaminated water, therefore increasing the risk of disease. Workers could become sick and take a break from their jobs which would worsen the situation. A

nother possibility is workers dying which implies that their job is a high risk, potentially stopping new workers from signing up. In return, people are afraid of the profession so the government wouldn't be able to find anyone to do the work. Governments should provide protective clothing along with proper training, as this would boost the rate of healthy sanitation in informal cities.

Against

However, trying to improve the working conditions in the sanitation department would be challenging as governments may lack the money to provide sufficient training to allow the workers to perform at their best. It would also be a challenge to provide the necessary equipment in informal cities as they have limited infrastructure. It would be difficult to access certain areas around the city and inadequate sewage systems can also make sanitation work difficult which increases the risk of danger.

In addition, setting up new workers and different standards may take some time to properly show advantages. Therefore, more waste could build up. Although there are a few challenges, governments should view this as motivation to implement better long term solutions to create a perfect workforce which would save informal cities from facing terrible sanitation problems.

In conclusion, sanitation workers are incredibly significant to protect public health and the environment, especially in informal settlements where sanitation services are usually terrible. And the infrastructure around is limited to an extent.

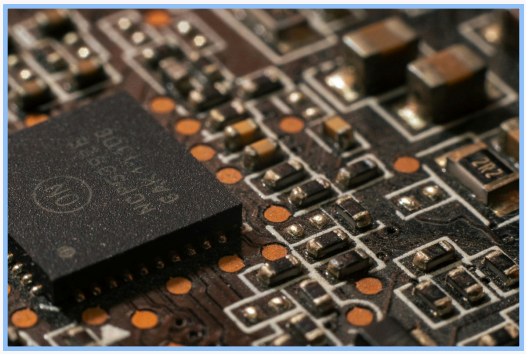
So although improving sanitation will require funding, human health and safety should be a priority above all. The government should be investing in better equipment, safety and training regulations so workers can perform to the best of their ability. By recognising sanitation workers and their roles, governments would be able to improve public health.

Jacob Derrett

From Code to Combat: Preventing the Weaponization of Quantum Technologies

The militarisation of quantum computing refers to the use of the principles of quantum mechanics to protect a nation's technological state. In the past 10 years, the militarisation of quantum computing has grown.

For example, the United States Department of Defence announced an investment of $350 million to boost its quantum computing strength. Additionally, foreign intelligence groups use quantum computing to attack a nation's GPS, which can cause transport and communication failures.

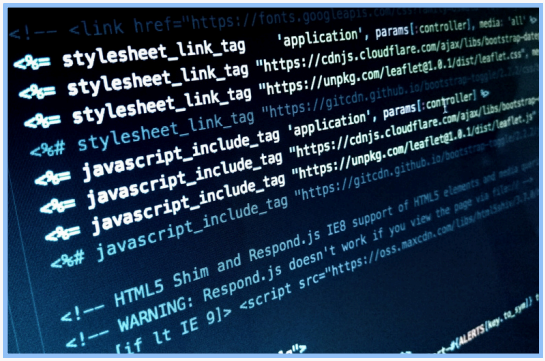


The militarisation of quantum computing also encourages intelligence agencies like the CIA in the United States, MI5 in the United Kingdom and MSS in China to actively attempt to steal highly encrypted information. Some discussions describe a "harvest now decrypt" approach, where an attacker captures or strategically intercepts highly encrypted network traffic or cloud backups even though they cannot decrypt it immediately with their current technological state.

The article cites a statement from the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) that encrypted data is still at risk because attackers may gather it now for quantum decryption. This shows that other countries can obtain information even if it is encrypted. Another method for intelligence agencies to break or disturb a nation's communications is by decrypting national secrets. Quantum computers can run algorithms like Shor's algorithm, which quickly finds the factors of a large number. This speed gives them the power to read intelligence, tactical plans and diplomatic cables.

Scientists are working to stop the militarisation of quantum computing. They have issued a rejection. Many quantum scientists have signed a declaration that they do not want quantum research to be used for warfare, population control or surveillance of another country or state without their consent. The risk of an arms race grows as the technology threatens global stability. Quantum research centres should be places of discovery, not tools of warfare. The militarisation of quantum computing also fuels an arms race and the concept of Q-Day. Q-Day is the point of time when quantum computers become powerful enough to break encryption keys.

When this happens countries will compete for superiority in militarisation: for example, the United States and China. This competition can increase tension between nations. It also may spark modern conflict. Another reason people oppose the militarisation of quantum computing is the fear that it could be used in other military operations such as nuclear warfare and it could create geopolitical tensions between countries and researchers make comparisons to the nuclear era warning that a global race to weaponize quantum adds to the geopolitical instability.



Overall, the use of quantum computing can vary depending on who is involved with the production. As they could use it for good as it can help GPS navigation and safety as the sensors can map underground infrastructure, monitor earthquakes and improve disaster response where traditional response fails.

As Michio Kaku quoted “Quantum computing is not just about making things faster. It is about doing things that were previously impossible”. This shows that without quantum computing some things were impossible such as efficient large number factoring (shors algorithm).

Reyhana Hamilton

Race, Rights, and Realpolitik: Georgia v.s Russia at the ICJ

Could you imagine being forcibly removed from the place you called home? That's what happened to the 20,000 civilians living in the South Ossetia region of Georgia during the Russia-Georgia war of 2008. Motives of racial discrimination, or just the aftermath of an unrelenting, ugly red-war?

The republic of Georgia brought the former to the court on the 12th August 2008, claiming that "the Russian Federation, through its state agents and entities exercising governmental authority, is responsible for serious violations under CERD (a 1865 UN committee established on the elimination of racial discrimination)." These allegations raised questions about the Russian motive in the war, with many citing that Russia's fear of Georgia joining NATO was perhaps not a valid reason for the mass killings of thousands of innocent civilians.

Could you expect anything other than Georgian victory in this case? Yet, it was Georgia's failure to attempt the establishment of negotiations with Russia that led to the dismissal of the case, dismissing the victims of ethnic cleansing.

Most would assume the global superpower, Russia, was at complete fault. However, when Georgian forces launched a military attack to retake the region of South Ossetia, they had no choice but to act. Their response was immediate: a large-scale invasion and the destruction of several Georgian cities through bombings. Though, why should this mean racially discriminating and murdering innocent Russian and Georgian civilians?

With the outbreak of the Russia-Georgia war on August 7th 2008, the republic of Georgia was growing increasingly concerned with the fatalities of their citizens and the destruction of their infrastructure and homes. Georgia had felt compelled to act, as their country would soon be shattered with the human and economic costs of the war. Therefore, they instituted an emergency provisional measure in relation to the CERD.

The CERD was allegedly breached by the Russian Federation in accordance with Georgia's submitted claim, relying on article 22 of CERD to protect its citizens against discrimination by the Russian forces. Article 22 was the foundational rule that explained how countries must settle legal disputes regarding racial discrimination, therefore a breach of this raised valid concern.

Responding to Georgia's emergency measure, the ICJ declared that "each party [Russia and Georgia] shall refrain from an action which might prejudice the rights of the other party..or which might aggravate the dispute". By ordering Russian forces within Georgia and regions of South Ossetia to abstain from acts of racial discrimination and defense of such discrimination, it finally provided ethnic Georgian and Russian civilians hope for peace and equality. Despite active combat only lasting around 5 days, they had been awaiting the confirmation for their safety for a grueling two months.

From a first glance, it appeared that Russia was at complete fault, but their subsequent objections gave greater insight into the true relationship between both states and how a lack of communication ended up being a killswitch.

The Russian federation filed four objections on the 1st of December 2009, more than a year after Georgia's rapid reaction. However, the court only addressed this in a judgement on 1st April 2011, delaying the case's final verdict that could have solved the grotesque, grisly tensions and violence in the Caucuses much sooner. The court considered Russia's first objection, where they stated that there had been no form of prior communication between the parties regarding the application of CERD at the date that Georgia had ordered it. Each side made compelling, counter arguments with the Georgian president Mikheil Saakashvili claiming that "Russian troops . . . expelled the whole ethnically Georgian population of South Ossetia".

This was then challenged by Russian foreign minister Sergey Lavrov who addressed these allegations and dismissed Saakashvili. However, it was discovered that there had indeed been a dispute between Georgia and the Russian federation about the latter's compliance with following the rules of CERD at the time that Georgia ordered the measure. Therefore, Russia's first preliminary order was dismissed.

Russia's secondary preliminary objection however put the nail in the coffin, as they argued that the procedure for Article 22 of CERD had not been fulfilled, such as; initial written communication, attempting a genuine negotiation before coming to the court, etc. The court noted that Georgia did not claim it had attempted to use such procedures used in CERD, therefore the conventional procedures under article 22 of CERD had not been met.

Russia's second preliminary objection was upheld and the court ruled on the long awaited judgement that Georgia's brief notice did not constitute a genuine attempt at prior negotiations and therefore the case was dismissed with provisional measures ceasing effect on April 1 2011.

The dismissal of the case severely impacted both sides, though not their government as much as their people. The citizens. The civilians. The people. The people who had to endure threats to their lives and their homes. Either side contributed to the destruction caused by the war, yet the biggest reason at fault would be their poor communication.

Perhaps, if there had been a genuine attempt at negotiations prior, then this case would have had a stronger impact on the lives of the people residing in this region. Georgia and the Russia still have threatening tensions today, and the dream of a peaceful life is appearing to be hopeless.

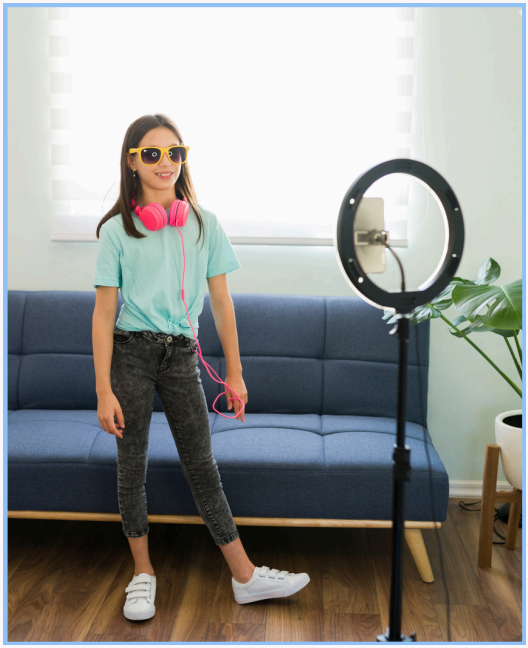
Haidee Williamson

Like, Follow, Exploit: Commercialising Childhood on Social Media

When a child works on a Hollywood movie set, state laws and regulations limit their working hours, and mandatory Coogan trust accounts are enforced to protect their wealth. When a child works for their parents for 40 hours a week in their own living room, advertising and promoting brands, they lack the legal right to their own paychecks and are labelled as hobbyists.

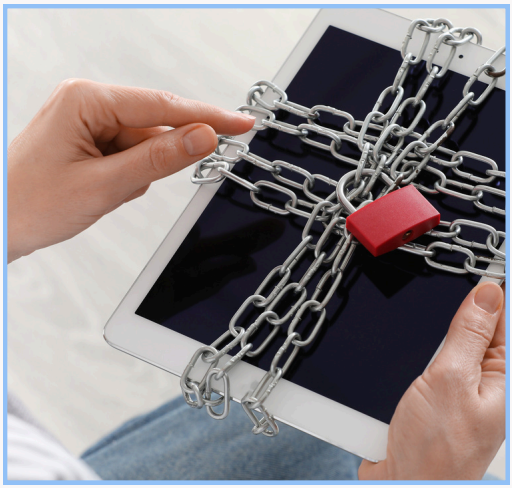
The life of a 'Kidfluencer' is not one that should be force-fed to any child. Similarly, 'Sharenting' should not call for parents to expose their child without consent on social media. An Oxford research shows that the average child will have around 1300 photos of themselves posted on social media platforms before the age of 13. Both terms stem from the concept of a guardian exploiting their child and commercialising them through monetization via social media. 'Kidfluencers' daily lives essentially transform into monetized labour: becoming a marketing tool.

This is then used against other children: UNICEF warns that "by... 14, children could be exposed to up to 1,260 ads each day on social media". 'Sharenting' on the other hand involves sharing private moments online, thus creating a potentially unwanted digital footprint for the minor involved without consent. UNICEF's response to this is emphasising the importance of teaching children consent, claiming we're "missing out on a valuable opportunity to teach our children". The lack of benefit to the child is further highlighted through the fact that the money received from the monetization is usually legally the parents' due to the lack of labor protection laws.



The exploitation of a child's daily life results in several negative consequences. The exposure to constant consumerism may result in traits such as materialism, anxiety, poor living habits, and lack of privacy with no guaranteed income. UNICEF data shows that commercial marketing is featured in 95% of children's apps. Additionally, the constant development of AI introduces several risks such as the manipulation of photos/videos of children shared online, resulting in an increase in privacy and safety threats.

UNICEF has repeatedly brought up the struggle to control commercialising children through social media through programmes such as the Child Right and Digital Marketing project, which targets modern digital marketing risks. Along with this, they've backed up legislative mandates that are specific to third-party exploitation of minors such as guidelines from Cambodia's ministry of social affairs that banned the use of children on social media for commercial purposes without legal consent. UNICEF publicly warns against the 'datafication' of childhood, stating that public commercial profiles result in children being highly vulnerable to privacy loss, exploitation, & AI deepfake manipulation.



Another way they've supported the end of commercialising children is through the belief in a 'safety by design' view - a response to blanket bans such as Australia's under 16 social media ban. UNICEF argues that restrictions alone do not work and can backfire by driving kids into unregulated places. The 'safety by design' framework pressures tech corps to fix systematic features by building strict privacy guardrails: restricting targeted advertising to minors & rewriting algorithms from the beginning to protect them rather than treat them as monetizable commodities.

Despite these efforts, problems still arise. Many guidelines offered by UNICEF are voluntary. Big tech platforms/marketing agencies can ignore them without any penalties. Legal frameworks should be enforced with fines for platforms that farm child data for targeted ads. UNICEF also acknowledges that child labor laws are offline, and are unequipped to handle home-based digital labour which may result in advertising networks and data brokers' exploitative practices to work behind the scenes, remaining unaddressed.

Along with this, most of the research driving UNICEF's digital marketing strategies are skewed toward high income, western nations, disregarding children in low-to-middle income countries - who are undergoing rapid smartphone adoption with no protection. This leaves millions exposed: more than 175,000 children globally gain access to the internet daily for the first time. Decentralising from western policy frameworks and helping weaker governments to enforce digital protections before tech corps control local digital markets should be the goal.

Ultimately, as the internet develops at a rapid pace, so do the problems that follow behind. 'Kidfluencers' and 'Sharenting' have transformed the private lives of children into marketing tools, leaving them vulnerable. UNICEF has pushed for solutions, however underlying issues remain unaddressed, such as home-based digital workers. The call to protect the next generation from commercial exploitation is mandatory and is the next step to legally prioritize child safety over monetized profit.

Haania Immad

Punished for Being Poor: The Case for Decriminalising Homelessness

There are millions of people all over the world who live in poverty, who are homeless with no place to stay. So do these people deserve to be punished for basic human needs? There are laws scattered across the whole world: prohibiting people to beg, sleep or stay outside in public, despite the fact that they sadly have nowhere else to go. Some countries even go so far as to charge and arrest public beggars, for the “crime” of mendicancy.

Despite the impending fact that many states have adequate resources and are able to place a suitable roof over many vagrants, there are approximately 381 million people who lack any type of stable shelter. These people are also in danger of getting fined or even taken to prison just for trying to survive like any other human. Actually, there are many laws across the globe which criminalise these activities such as Hungary, whose government stated in their Fundamental Law constitution “using a public space as a habitual dwelling shall be prohibited”, even allowing police to issue fines, community service or custodial sentences to people sleeping rough.

There are many countries which also have a legal restriction to vagrancy and street sleeping although there is mainly no official constitutional law. Though it seems outrageous, cities all across North America, Europe, Asia and Australia take the time to build structures like benches with center armrests and metal studs on the floor to stop people resting on streets, when homeless people could be gotten rid of by giving them a home instead, which would use the money that would have been spent on useless uncomfortable resting spots. The fact that roughly 4% to less than 5% of the global population lack basic housing seems like a small amount, when so many people are suffering without a proper home. So why are people taking this and turning it into a crime punishable by law?

The thing is, these people cannot help being homeless, and did not choose this way of living. What good does it do punishing them? Allowing these poor people to simply exist and try their best to endure life does not do any harm to the country. Having an unhoused person pay a fine does no good, as there is a high chance they will not be able to pay the full amount. As was mentioned before, building structures which deliberately stop people from camping/resting on streets is so normalized, when the poor people just want somewhere to stay.

Spending money on these structures, money which could have gone to shelters or charities feels appalling, and does not do any good for the city. It should be a human right to have access to adequate housing, and be given a place to live without worrying about the weather, and other pains of staying outside. Instead of normalizing homelessness, we should be trying our best to end it. Even donating a small amount could help take someone into a shelter, and keep people safe.

All in all, people in poverty, specifically those who lack housing should be helped, and be given a roof over their heads. Instead of charging or even imprisoning, our community should aim to help the best we can. Everyone deserves a place to stay, and somewhere to call home. We should treat homelessness as a "systematic failure and a human rights crisis" and strive to create an environment where nations help people who live without a home, instead of punishing them for already suffering.

Inayah Bhutta

The Silent Pandemic: Antimicrobial Resistance and the Food We Eat

Imagine going to bed with a tiny scratch on your knee from playing football, and waking up with a giant infection that no doctor can fix. It sounds like a scary movie, right? But scientists are warning that this could actually happen because of something called the "silent pandemic" of Antimicrobial Resistance (AMR).

Why is everyone calling it a silent pandemic? It turns out, it's not a loud virus like COVID-19. Instead, it is a sneaky, invisible change happening inside the bacteria all around us—especially in the food we eat every single day.

What is AMR and Why Are Bacteria Turning into Superbugs?

When we get really sick with a bacterial infection, doctors give us a type of medicine called antibiotics. These are like tiny superheroes that wipe out the bad bugs. But bacteria are smart. If they see the same medicine over and over again, they learn how to fight back. They mutate and change their DNA so the medicine doesn't hurt them anymore.

When that happens, normal bacteria turn into unstoppable "superbugs." If we run out of medicines that work, even simple things like a throat infection or a scraped elbow could become incredibly dangerous.

How Superbugs Get on Our Dinner Plates?

You might think you only get antibiotics when you are sick in bed, but most of the world's antibiotics are actually given to farm animals!

- Crowded Farms: To grow enough food for billions of people, millions of chickens, camels, and cows are raised in tight spaces.
- Medicine as a Shield: Instead of just treating sick animals, farms often feed them low doses of antibiotics every day to prevent them from getting sick or to make them grow bigger, faster.
- The Mutation Station: This constant stream of medicine creates the perfect training ground for superbugs to grow inside the animals' stomachs.

When the animals are processed for food, those superbugs can hitch a ride on the meat. They can also get into our water systems through farm runoff, which means they can end up on fruits and vegetables that are watered with that same water. When we handle or eat this food, the superbugs can get into our bodies.

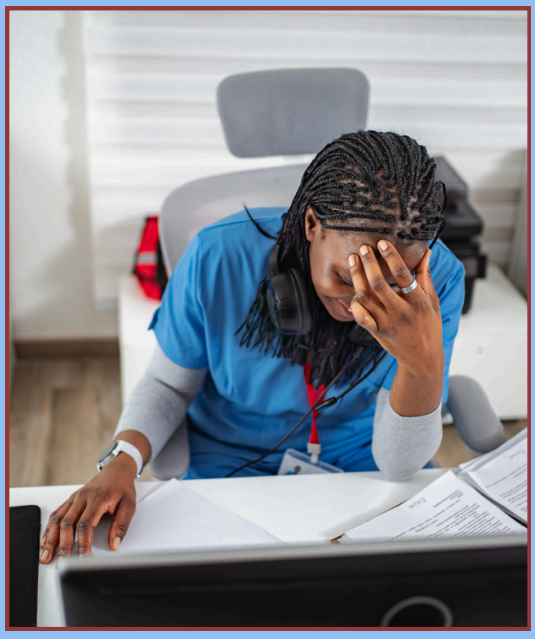
Why Is This A Big Deal For This Generation?

According to scientists, AMR is already directly responsible for more than 1.2 million deaths every year. If we don't change how we farm and use medicine right now, experts predict that up to 10 million people could die each year by 2050. That is when kids my age will be adults! The World Bank also warns that it could make millions of people very poor because healthcare will become too expensive and people won't be able to work.

Ahana Purohit

Underpaid and Overlooked: Elevating Women in Health and Care

Women make up about 67 % to 70% of the global health and social care workforce, yet they remain heavily underpaid ,undervalued and under-represented in leadership roles with only 25% of the workforce. Women who work the same amount of hours with an average of about 76%, as men only earn 24% less than men on average, creating severe poverty. Examples of this can be in Sub-Sarahan Africa, South Sudan and the Central African Republic. The International Labour Organization report also finds out that women during pregnancy suffer way worse as pay gaps significantly increase.



The World Health Organization or WHO discussed this issue and outlined a list of measures when it came to inequality, especially when it's women who work in the health care force and are underpaid. The first one is by improving working conditions. This can be done by actively upgrading safety protections against sexual harassment and workplace violence. Secondly, and most importantly is by enforcing equal pay. This can even be through the motherhood penalty by ensuring their career still goes and whilst getting a fair wage during and after reproductive years. Thirdly, is equality transitions into paid labour done through authorizing unusual patterns into formalized and salaried legally protected jobs.

Women who are underpaid in the health care work force would be forced to drop out. This would be a disadvantage to business as they rely on continuous labour throughout. Governments and health care systems mostly see females in the frontlines as "volunteers" or "community activists" as an excuse to avoid paying them fair wages. This takes a toll on their mental health. With a staggering amount of at least 69% having a severe amount of burnout, anxiety, and imposter syndrome compared to 56% of men. In terms of physical pain, over 50% experience chronic back and joint pain, fatigue, and musculoskeletal disorders.

One of the most urgent measures is to introduce stronger equal pay policies across healthcare organisations. A joint report by the WHO and the International Labour Organization (ILO), published in July 2022, found that women working in the health and care sector earn approximately 24% less than men when factors such as age, education and working time are considered. The analysis examined data from 54 countries, demonstrating that this is a widespread international problem rather than an isolated issue.

To understand the scale of this inequality, consider two hypothetical healthcare workers with comparable qualifications and responsibilities. If a male employee earns $50,000 annually, a 24% difference would mean a female employee earns $38,000. This represents a difference of $12,000 per year. Over ten years, the difference could amount to $120,000 before considering promotions, savings or investment returns, assuming the annual gap remains constant.

These conditions can also threaten patient safety. Exhausted and overworked healthcare workers may find it more difficult to concentrate, communicate effectively, and make decisions under pressure. Therefore, improving women's working conditions is not only a matter of gender equality; it is also necessary to protect patients and maintain reliable healthcare services

In conclusion, elevating the position of women in the health and care workforce requires a combined effort from governments, employers and society. Equal pay, fair promotion opportunities, safer workplaces and access to education are essential steps towards reducing gender inequality. Women play a vital role in maintaining public health and supporting vulnerable communities, and their work deserves equal recognition, respect and reward. By implementing these measures, healthcare systems can become fairer, stronger and more inclusive for everyone.

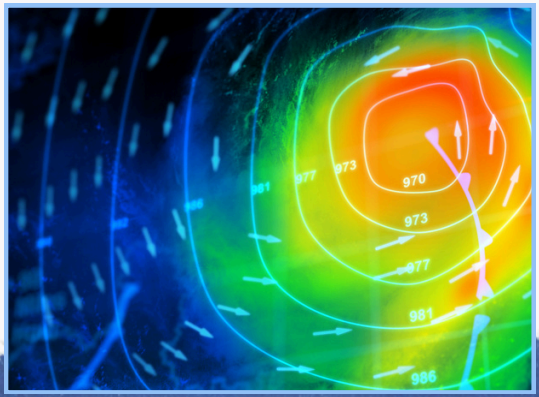
Jordan Msefula

Building Back in Madagascar: Humanitarian Response to Cyclone Gezani

Cyclones are a large-scale system of winds that rotate inward around a center of low atmospheric pressure; they form over warm ocean waters when surface temperatures reach 26.5 degrees Celsius. The southern African region, with countries like Madagascar and Mozambique, are prone to cyclones having one nearly every single year, consequently they have a long historical pattern of cyclones. This is due to the fact that the countries sit in the path of tropical systems that develop across the southern Indian Ocean.

Earlier this year, Cyclone Gezani occurred in Madagascar on Wednesday, February 11th. It impacted the east coast in a city called Toasmina. Gezani then moved inland towards the west coast, downgrading to heavy but destructive rainfall injuring cities like Antananarivo and Ambatandrozak. The rainfall resulted in flooding and power outages, limiting their ability to access help. Preventing anybody to provide them with the proper medical care, shelter and any attention that they need. As well as this, powerful winds up to 185 km per hour caused around 250,000 people to be affected, millions displaced, over 40 dead, and at least 25 still missing.

With no roof and damaged land, the aspect of food insecurity has plummeted, becoming more difficult for the people of Madagascar. According to the IPC (Integrated food security phase classification system), cyclone Gezani moved Madagascar from Phase 3 (Crisis) to Phase 4 (Emergency) and will progressively get worse as time goes by. Phase 3 is described as households facing significant food consumption gaps or meeting their minimum food needs by using critical and unsustainable coping strategies. In this phase, Global Acute Malnutrition (GAM) rates are typically high or above normal levels, ranging from 10 to 15%.



While, Phase 4, where the conditions are much more severe, are chronicled as at least 20% of households facing food shortages, people typically taking fewer than 2100 calories per day. GAM rates are very high reaching about 30% of the population. This puts vulnerable groups such as: children, disabled, elderly, sick and impoverished individuals at greater risks. Furthermore, Cyclone Gezani has not only harmed Madagascar but also the southern coastal province of Inhambane and parts of Sofala. There were 4 people found dead and over 130,000 people lost power. Although Cyclone Gezani had affected fewer people in Mozambique, they still suffered casualties from the cataclysm.

It is evident that the natural disaster Cyclone Gezani has caused havoc and critical infrastructure to Madagascar and parts of Southern Africa and will continue to in the near future. The government has already installed text alerts and systems to warn people when the cyclones are coming. Disaster committees help plan a safe route to escape. The UN has published safety guides on disaster safety, whereas humanitarian groups distribute shelter kits. However many people, including both the vulnerable and mainstream population, may not have access to those resources in urgent situations. Implementing public basements all around high-risk cyclone zoned countries resolves the lack of safety in public spaces by reassuring civilians that there is a haven for everyone to go during a cyclone. These basements will include food, water, toiletries, and other necessities that they may need. They will fit roughly 30 people each and have supplies for at least a month. Following this protocol helps ensure the safeguarding of everybody.

All things considered, Madagascar has suffered a terrible tragedy, with starvation rates skyrocketing, loss of lives increasing day by day and many innocent civilians being displaced from their homes. The best way we can help them is to provide them with the care and protection that they need.

Daniyah Ahmed

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